The next call was to President Truman. Kennedy continued with his deception tactics, although Truman never asked any explicit question about Turkey. “Then on Saturday morning, twelve hours after the other letter was received, we got this entirely different letter about the missile bases in Turkey,” said Kennedy, recounting the letter drama. “That’s the way they do things,” responded Truman. “Then, well then we rejected that,” continued Kennedy. “Then they came back … and accepted the earlier proposal.” Truman told Kennedy that he was on the right track. Hoover, whom Kennedy got on the line next, was in agreement with Truman. He told Kennedy: “It seems to me these recent events are rather incredible.” “They are incredible,” responded Kennedy. “That represents a good triumph for you,” remarked Hoover.[11]

From this point on, Kennedy had no way back in his concealment of the secret deal with Khrushchev, but one thing he decided not to do was to commit the deal to paper. Khrushchev, meanwhile, wanted Kennedy’s promise in writing. On October 29, Dobrynin got in touch with Robert Kennedy once again, this time to pass a confidential letter from Khrushchev to the president. “Dear Mr. President,” began the message, “Ambassador Dobrynin has apprised me of his conversation with Robert Kennedy which took place on October 27.” Khrushchev thanked Kennedy for having his brother convey the offer to remove American missiles from Turkey and explained that his agreement to Kennedy’s official terms had been influenced by the president’s unofficial offer. Khrushchev had no problem in conducting secret negotiations and was ready to keep that channel open. “I feel I must state to you that I do understand the delicacy involved for you in an open consideration of the issue of eliminating the US missile bases in Turkey,” wrote Khrushchev. “I take into account the complexity of this issue, and I believe you are right about not wishing to publicly discuss it.”[12]

The next day, Robert Kennedy assured Dobrynin that the president would honor his word but could not sign any letters, even the most secret ones. “We … are not prepared,” said Robert to Dobrynin, “to formulate such an understanding in the form of letters, even the most confidential letters, between the President and the head of the Soviet government when it concerns such a highly delicate issue. Speaking in all candor, I myself, for example, do not want to risk getting involved in the transmission of this sort